

Chapter 164-1

It wasn't sweet talk spoken in the heat of passion.

Nor was it icing on the cake for momentary pleasure.

It was a promise made after careful deliberation.

Cold sunlight refracted through the window, dust dancing in the light, all falling on Liang Shi's back.

Outside, the wind whistled past the window frame. The traffic on Yujiang Bridge slowly returned to normal.

The bustling city came back to life in an instant.

All that remained in the living room was the sound of their intertwined breaths.

Slow and gentle, with a hint of caution.

After a long while, Liang Shi leaned back, ending the lingering kiss.

She then raised her hand to wipe away Xu Qingzhu's tears. "Are you hungry? I'll go make food."

Xu Qingzhu let out a soft "mm" through her nose, but when Liang Shi stood up, Xu Qingzhu reached out and tugged at the hem of her clothes.

With the bottom of her clothes gently held by Xu Qingzhu, Liang Shi's collar tilted slightly, revealing her collarbone and a bit of shoulder.

Liang Shi turned to look at her and said softly: "What is it?"

Xu Qingzhu sniffled, her reddened eyes staring at her intently: "One more hug~"

Her cool voice carried a hint of softness, sounding aggrieved.

Liang Shi's heart melted completely. She knelt with one knee on the sofa and leaned in to embrace her.

Their tightly embraced bodies allowed them to feel each other's warmth and heartbeat—a warmth and peace of mind they hadn't had in so long.

Xu Qingzhu's head was buried in her shoulder. Liang Shi patted her back. "Alright, aren't you hungry? I really won't leave."

Even this assurance couldn't make Xu Qingzhu let go. She still held tightly onto Liang Shi's waist.

Xu Qingzhu's cool voice carried some softness and huskiness as she said quietly: "You've gotten thinner."

As she spoke, she pinched Liang Shi's waist—only managing to pinch a thin layer of flesh that quickly slipped from between her fingers.

"You have the nerve to say that about me?" Liang Shi stroked her back. "Can't you see how thin you've become? Really, you need to eat properly."

"It's not like anyone's been cooking for me," Xu Qingzhu complained. "I've been trying hard to eat every day, but when I'm in a bad mood, I eat and then throw up. It's an endless cycle. I'm having a hard time too, you know?"

Hearing this, Liang Shi's guilt deepened. She let out a low sigh. All eloquent words seemed insignificant at this moment.

After much thought, the only words she could manage were: "I'm sorry."

"Then you have to be nicer to me." Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together, turned her face, and kissed her neck lightly, leaving a moist trace. "Even if you're not nice to me, at least be nice to your child. Otherwise, when she's born, I'll..."

She suddenly stopped mid-sentence.

Liang Shi asked gently: "You'll what?"

"I can't do anything." Xu Qingzhu's voice suddenly softened, seeming somewhat helpless. "I'll tell her it's because I wasn't good enough that I couldn't keep you."

Liang Shi: "....."

After holding each other quietly for a while longer, Liang Shi finally got up and went to the kitchen. But while she was washing rice, she suddenly thought of something...

Liang Shi turned around and happened to lock eyes with Xu Qingzhu, who had tiptoed into the kitchen behind her.

Their eyes met. Xu Qingzhu suddenly stood on tiptoe, leaned forward, and kissed her.

Liang Shi was stunned. She slowly stuck out the tip of her tongue and lightly licked her lips, as if savoring the taste.

Xu Qingzhu's eyes held a faint smile—this was probably the happiest expression she had shown since they reunited.

Not that fearful unease, nor the crying she couldn't stop.

Simply a mischievous smile from inner satisfaction.

"What?" Seeing Liang Shi dazed, Xu Qingzhu's tone rose slightly. "Gone silly?"

"No..." Liang Shi reflexively denied.

But undeniably, Xu Qingzhu's unexpected kiss had made her heart race and her mind go blank for a moment.

She couldn't tell if it was because of the kiss or because of Xu Qingzhu's smile.

Probably both.

Liang Shi turned around somewhat flustered, turned on the faucet, and continued rinsing the rice.

Only after finishing did she remember what she had wanted to say.

But first she put the washed rice with water into the rice cooker, plugged it in, and pressed the cook button. Only then did she turn around unhurriedly—but the moment she turned, a pair of hands reached around her waist from behind and embraced her.

Liang Shi's somewhat cold hands fell on Xu Qingzhu's hands, patting the back of them.

Xu Qingzhu said: "Why didn't you use hot water?"

"It hadn't warmed up yet," Liang Shi said. "It's always cold water at first."

"Even colder than my hands," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi nodded: "Who would have thought?"

Liang Shi graciously went along with Xu Qingzhu's words.

But after a moment, Liang Shi still said quietly: "Earlier, you..."

She paused, her voice drowned out by the sound of the refrigerator door opening. After closing the refrigerator door, Liang Shi pretended to speak casually: "Were you pretending?"

That word seemed a bit harsh.

But Liang Shi couldn't think of a more suitable word.

Xu Qingzhu's arms around her stiffened. Then Liang Shi added: "Not pretending—acting. Just now in the living room..."

"Huh?" Xu Qingzhu played dumb. "Acting what?"

"That's clearly not how you are," Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu: "...Then how should I be?"

One sentence blocked Liang Shi's words completely.

How should Xu Qingzhu be?

"Maybe because you don't like me, you feel like everything about me is wrong." Xu Qingzhu rubbed against her back, her voice sad. "I was like this before too."

Liang Shi: "....."

The green pepper in her hands had already been torn apart. Liang Shi absent-mindedly broke it into pieces and tossed them into a plate.

Chapter 164-2

After a while, Liang Shi said seriously: "You were acting."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"I really won't leave." Liang Shi said, "And I really do love you. Please don't make me feel bad by putting yourself down, okay? I like you. Hearing you say bad things about yourself hurts more than hearing you scold me."

Liang Shi never turned around. Although her hands were doing things, she was in a numb state.

The hardest, most embarrassing words had already been said. What came after wasn't difficult at all—like pouring beans out of a bamboo tube¹, all the words came spilling out.

"I wanted to divorce you because I thought you could have a better life, a better future without me. It's not that I don't love you. I chose to leave the place where I grew up to find you precisely because I love you."

"Xu Qingzhu, you're really wonderful. So, so wonderful that sometimes I feel like I don't deserve you. You're too perfect, just like Lu Jiayi. Your education, looks, personality, abilities, family background—everything is top-notch. So I often think, what can I do for you? It seems like I can't do anything."

"What I can do for you is utterly ordinary—any regular housekeeper or nanny could do it. But can I keep playing this role by your side forever? You'll get tired of me sooner or later, won't you? I always think, it would be better if I left before you got tired of me."

"As long as I leave first, you'll be sad for a while but then you'll get over it. A brighter future awaits you, and I won't have to constantly worry about gains and losses. I want to be with you, but I always overthink things. I don't want to become a burden in your life."

"I also don't want people to see us together and say, 'Oh, this person has nothing—is President Xu blind to fall for someone like this?' Whether it hurts my self-esteem is secondary. What matters most is that your reputation would be damaged."

"From beginning to end, I never said I don't love you. Maybe I don't love you as much as you love me, or as much as I love myself. But in this world, you really are the person I love the most."

"So please don't feel insecure, okay? Think about it—here, I'm close to almost no one but you. Only you know everything about me, know that I came from somewhere else, know that I have nowhere else to go. Where could I possibly go?"

When Liang Shi called Xu Qingzhu's name, it was slow and gentle.

She spoke these words unhurriedly, breaking the green pepper in her hands into small pieces, her eyes lowered.

"Xu Qingzhu, you really are wonderful. Please don't put yourself down just to keep me by your side, okay? I love you. No matter what, I love you. Even when you don't love me..."

She paused: "I'll still remember all those moments when you loved me, and love you."

Xu Qingzhu hadn't said anything the entire time. Her face was pressed against Liang Shi's shoulder, warm.

Liang Shi's voice was gentle yet sincere as she made a promise: "From now on, I'll try to do this."

It was just love, after all.

At worst, she'd be hurt until she was battered and bruised.

At least she would have loved.

Her previous timid behavior had caused psychological trauma to Xu Qingzhu. At worst, she could let Xu Qingzhu hurt her once—consider it repayment.

Love couldn't be measured on a scale, but one could decide whether to love and how deeply.

So she would love as deeply as she could.

To love once was to not waste a passionate life.

Liang Shi comforted herself this way.

After she finished speaking, the kitchen was silent for a long time.

Liang Shi nervously, cautiously asked: "Was I too blunt? I'm not saying you can't act or pretend. I just... don't want you to be so busy and still have to do these things with me. It's too hard on you. I'll love you anyway."

This clumsy supplementary excuse finally made Xu Qingzhu burst out laughing.

"What are you laughing at?" Liang Shi asked in a muffled voice.

Xu Qingzhu's head bumped against her back in small motions, one after another. First she laughed quietly, then buried herself in Liang Shi's back and laughed out loud, her whole body trembling.

Which made Liang Shi's body shake along with her.

Liang Shi didn't know what had happened.

She didn't think she'd said anything funny. She was being very serious.

But Xu Qingzhu's current reaction was unpredictable, so she could only wait and see.

After several long minutes, Xu Qingzhu finally spoke slowly: "Dummy."

With a hint of coquettish reproach.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her cheek against Liang Shi's thin back again and said quietly: "I don't think it's hard."

"Those days after you left the divorce agreement and walked away—that was hard." Xu Qingzhu said, "I felt like loving you was so hard. I didn't dare ask anything. Whatever you didn't want to say, I didn't ask. I don't know where you came from, where you're going. I don't even know who you are."

"But after thinking all that, I still couldn't help missing you. Wondering how you were doing out there, whether you'd eaten, whether you missed me, whether you were sad about the divorce—even if just for a moment."

"I thought about so many things... I even told myself to stop liking Liang Shi. But I couldn't control it. I just kept missing you. I just didn't want to divorce you. I just wanted to... keep you."

"What I did earlier was an act." Xu Qingzhu admitted, "I know..."

She paused, took a deep breath, as if summoning courage before saying: "Your personality weakness... so I used this method. But what can I do... you still saw through it..."

She spoke haltingly, her voice very low, using barely audible breaths when she felt guilty.

It was lucky the house was quiet. Liang Shi held her breath while listening to her.

So she could clearly hear every word she said.

"Would you call this prescribing the right medicine for the illness?" Liang Shi heard the nervousness in her voice and teased her warmly with a smile.

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu shook her head, rubbing it against Liang Shi's back.

"It was a bit underhanded." Xu Qingzhu said quietly, "I'm sorry."

"What's there to be sorry about?" Liang Shi said, "If you hadn't pushed me, I'd still be hiding in my shell, too scared to come out, and I wouldn't be able to hold you."

Xu Qingzhu said in a muffled voice: "Don't you... find me scary like this?"

The kitchen suddenly fell silent. Liang Shi tossed the last piece of crushed green pepper into the plate, turned around and wrapped her arms around Xu Qingzhu, propping her hands up and trying to keep them away from her back.

"You dared to love someone as timid as me." Liang Shi kissed her forehead. "So what does it matter if I love someone as scary as you?"

In that moment, Xu Qingzhu looked up at her.

Fireworks suddenly exploded in her heart.

¹ **Pouring beans out of a bamboo tube (竹筒倒豆子):** A Chinese idiom meaning to confess everything completely and unreservedly, like how beans would all pour out at once when you tip over a bamboo tube. It describes speaking frankly without holding anything back.

Chapter 164-3

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There's a saying that goes: a brief separation is better than a new marriage¹.

Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi had never experienced the state of being newlyweds, but who knew if this counted.

After clearing the air, Xu Qingzhu clung to Liang Shi's side like a koala.

Liang Shi was afraid of hurting her and worried about the stability of her pregnancy, so she just wanted her to sit and rest properly.

But Xu Qingzhu had an attitude of "if you don't rest, I won't rest either," so after they finished eating, Liang Shi didn't even have time to wash the dishes. She just washed her hands and sat there to keep Xu Qingzhu company.

Before long, Xu Qingzhu started yawning, so Liang Shi accompanied her back to the bedroom.

Lying on the bed she hadn't seen in so long, with the person she hadn't seen in so long beside her.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu clung tightly together. Neither spoke, just looking at each other up close, both feeling content.

Xu Qingzhu would occasionally lean over to kiss Liang Shi.

Liang Shi would also sneak a kiss when Xu Qingzhu wasn't paying attention.

Back and forth they went.

Like they were playing some kind of game.

But after just a few minutes, Liang Shi touched the ends of Xu Qingzhu's hair and said gently: "Go to sleep."

Xu Qingzhu yawned and said she wasn't tired. Seeing this made Liang Shi want to laugh, but she just wiped away Xu Qingzhu's tears, gently kissed her eyelids and forehead, coaxing her like a child: "Go to sleep now."

"What if you sneak away again while I'm sleeping?" Xu Qingzhu said, "...That's what you did last time."

Liang Shi: "....."

"There definitely won't be a next time." Liang Shi said, "I'll never be such a jerk again."

Xu Qingzhu pouted: "I'm scared to sleep. What if I wake up and find out this was all a dream?"

Hearing this, Liang Shi waited a moment, then leaned over and bit her cheek, leaving a very faint mark. "Does it hurt?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She raised her hand to cover her face, her eyes looking aggrieved: "Why did you bite my face?"

At this moment, Xu Qingzhu's voice was soft and sweet. Even though her eyes usually looked distant, under her aggrieved and pitiful gaze, she was utterly endearing.

"Then how about... you bite me too?" Liang Shi extended her arm.

Xu Qingzhu opened her mouth wide as if about to bite, but then fainted, changed direction, and bit directly onto Liang Shi's lips.

Liang Shi had been lying on her side when she was suddenly knocked backward. Her arm braced behind her.

Worried about hurting Xu Qingzhu, she simply placed her hand on Xu Qingzhu's waist, prioritizing protecting her.

After biting, Xu Qingzhu licked her lips, then raised her hand to slowly wipe away the moisture on her lips.

The slowed-down motion looked like an infinite replay.

Liang Shi buried her face in Xu Qingzhu's neck and coaxed her softly: "Baby, go to sleep."

"Oh right." Xu Qingzhu asked, "After she's born, will you still call me that?"

Liang Shi: "?"

Xu Qingzhu was! Acting! Cute!

It was a very soft and sweet voice, with a hint of grievance and uncertainty.

Enough to make one's heart flutter.

Liang Shi swallowed and deliberately asked: "Call you what?"

"Just... baby." Xu Qingzhu said those two words in a breathy voice.

Liang Shi asked back: "Why wouldn't I?"

"When she's born, she'll be tiny and so cute. She'll be the baby, and I'll be..." Xu Qingzhu paused mid-sentence, then said dejectedly: "...not anymore."

"How could that be?" Liang Shi was amused by her tone. "After she's born, she'll just be... a little one. You're the baby, the darling."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"Won't she be upset if she hears that?" Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi couldn't hold back anymore and laughed.

Buried in Xu Qingzhu's neck, she laughed without restraint.

Xu Qingzhu lightly punched her. "What are you laughing at?"

"Darling, how are you so cute?" Liang Shi reached out and gently pinched her face.

Xu Qingzhu huffed softly. "That's only because my Teacher Liang is too popular."

As she spoke, her eyes suddenly flickered, and her tone changed instantly. "What happened to your hand?"

Liang Shi let out a startled "ah" and immediately hid her hand behind her back. "What do you mean?"

These little movements naturally didn't escape Xu Qingzhu's eyes.

"Your hand." Xu Qingzhu repeated.

But Liang Shi instinctively continued hiding it. After a moment, under the pressure of Xu Qingzhu's gaze, she brought her hand out and said with feigned nonchalance: "It's nothing."

"An allergic reaction?" Xu Qingzhu stared at the small red dots on her hand.

Liang Shi nodded.

Xu Qingzhu frowned: "What did you touch?"

"Green peppers," Liang Shi said. "I was breaking them apart earlier."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

It was also Liang Shi's fault. She had been so focused on talking to Xu Qingzhu that she forgot about her green pepper allergy.

Back then, she had only used the original owner's body for three months. After getting her own body back, she had developed the habit of not drinking milk, yet forgot that she was actually allergic to green peppers.

Footnotes:

¹ **A brief separation is better than a new marriage (小別勝新婚):** A Chinese proverb meaning that reuniting after a short separation can be even sweeter and more passionate than the honeymoon period of a new marriage. The longing during absence makes the reunion more precious.

Chapter 164-4

Seeing Xu Qingzhu about to get up to fetch medicine for her, Liang Shi immediately pressed her down. "I've already applied medicine. It'll be gone after I sleep."

Xu Qingzhu was skeptical.

Liang Shi continued to reassure her: "Really, I'm not lying."

Only then did Xu Qingzhu lie back down, though she held onto Liang Shi's hand.

After a moment, she suddenly blew gently on Liang Shi's reddened hand, her expression serious and devout.

As if she were praying.

It was clearly her hand being blown on, yet Liang Shi felt her heart itch.

When Xu Qingzhu finished blowing and looked up, she saw Liang Shi staring at her with tears welling in her eyes.

Xu Qingzhu smiled: "What are you looking at?"

Liang Shi hugged her, her leg pressing on top of her too—but only for a moment. Remembering she was pregnant, she immediately withdrew.

Liang Shi said: "Looking at my wife."

Xu Qingzhu laughed softly. "Am I good-looking?"

"Good-looking." Liang Shi said, "No one is as good-looking as my wife."

Xu Qingzhu continued to laugh, smile reaching her eyes and brows.

Liang Shi held her, her heart melting completely. She leaned close to her ear and whispered: "Wife~"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "I'm here."

"Wife~" Liang Shi called again.

Xu Qingzhu answered again: "Mm-hmm."

Liang Shi continued calling: "Wife~"

Xu Qingzhu laughed: "What is it?"

As she spoke, she suddenly leaned close to Liang Shi's ear, gently bit her earlobe, then called out in a breathy voice: "Wife~"

Liang Shi smiled gently too, feeling like her whole being was about to melt.

How should that feeling be described?

It was probably like lying on soft, fluffy clouds, her whole body tingling pleasantly.

A bit at a loss for what to do, but just wanting to smile.

Holding this person made her so content that she didn't want to think about anything else, as if she had the whole world.

Then Liang Shi said quietly: "What you just did, it was like when we were little."

"Hm?" Xu Qingzhu asked first: "When we were little?"

After saying this, she suddenly became alert: "You... you remember?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Back when we were tied up by those people, you blew on my hand like this too."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Speaking of which, that really was a distant memory.

When she first saw Liang Shi again, she would always recall it, and each time she remembered, it hurt. It felt like her entire life was buried there.

She was scared, terrified.

But now when Liang Shi suddenly brought it up, Xu Qingzhu surprisingly didn't feel it was painful.

Instead, she accurately located that spot in her memory.

Back then, Liang Shi's hand had been bitten and the skin broken. Xu Qingzhu had done the same thing—cupped her hand and blown on it gently.

Thinking about it now, it actually seemed rather sweet.

There was a sense of secrecy that only the two of them in the whole world knew about.

Yet Xu Qingzhu was surprised: "You actually still remember. I thought you'd forgotten."

Liang Shi smiled. "I had completely forgotten, but then I remembered again."

It was when she went to that world. It's just that she never had the chance to tell Xu Qingzhu afterward.

Liang Shi suddenly asked: "So is that why you married me... her back then?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded, saying self-deprecatingly: "Didn't expect I'd marry the wrong person."

"If I hadn't experienced it myself, I wouldn't believe such a bizarre thing could happen either," Liang Shi said.

The two chatted idly. Although they mentioned things from childhood, they tacitly avoided bringing up those events.

Instead, they just chatted casually.

With no particular topic at all.

Before long, Xu Qingzhu fell asleep.

Liang Shi gently kissed her forehead: "Good afternoon, my darling."

Chapter 164-5

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In the evening, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu went to Zhao Xuning's place together to pack up her things.

But Xu Qingzhu didn't go upstairs. She was still a bit sleepy, so she closed her eyes and dozed in the car.

Liang Shi said she'd just go up and bring Zhao Xuning down, and the three of them could have dinner together.

Zhao Xuning happened to be home, sitting alone on the sofa drinking and watching TV—a hot-blooded anime.

Liang Shi was surprised when she saw it. "You actually watch this?"

Zhao Xuning: "The TV randomly recommended it."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi briefly told Zhao Xuning about going back, but Zhao Xuning didn't show any surprise at all, as if she had expected it long ago. She sat on the sofa with complete composure, continuing to drink.

Liang Shi asked her: "Aren't you on shift tonight?"

Zhao Xuning: "I'm on annual leave."

Liang Shi: "....."

After a moment, Liang Shi said in amazement: "How rare. The workaholic actually isn't working."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

When Liang Shi came out after packing her things, Zhao Xuning finally said in a seemingly calm manner: "Shen Hui seems to be getting engaged."

"What?" Liang Shi was shocked. "To who? Is it Yan Lin? This fast?"

Zhao Xuning: ".....No."

Liang Shi didn't speak.

She only heard Zhao Xuning say slowly: "It's one of our college classmates."

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi didn't know how to comfort her, so she could only force out: "Then have a good time."

Zhao Xuning frowned: "Good time doing what?"

"Aren't you taking annual leave to go out and relax?" Liang Shi said. "Then just find a place with nice scenery."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

The living room was silent for a long time.

After a long while, Zhao Xuning finally asked: "If I copied Gu Yixue and crashed the wedding, what do you think my chances of success would be?"

Liang Shi: ".....?"

"I can't estimate that." Liang Shi said very seriously, "But I think your chances of ending up in the police station are one hundred percent."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

That was the truth.

Shen Hui and Shen Fenghe had completely different personalities.

Shen Hui looked prickly on the surface, but deep down she was actually a very emotional person, and her mouth was hard but her heart was soft.

Liang Shi still remembered when Shen Hui had handed her tissues at the hospital back then.

If it weren't for Zhao Xuning having such a bitter falling out with her back then, with such a heart-wrenching breakup, Shen Hui wouldn't be so at odds with Zhao Xuning now.

But someone like Shen Fenghe prioritized benefits above all, always kept her word, and had no feelings between her and Gu Yixue—probably none with Gu Chunmian either.

That's why she agreed to Gu Yixue at the wedding.

Speaking of which, she hadn't contacted Gu Yixue in a long time.

Maybe Gu Yixue had gone on her honeymoon. She hadn't even posted on her social media these days—completely off the grid.

One was entangled by interests, the other was entangled by emotions.

Gu Yixue's odds of winning were much higher than Zhao Xuning's.

But...

Liang Shi couldn't help but ask: "What are you two even doing? Can't date properly, can't break up properly, can't get back together properly—does Shen Hui owe you something?"

Zhao Xuning, suddenly being lectured: "?"

Even though Zhao Xuning had an iceberg face, Liang Shi wasn't afraid of her.

After spending so many days together, Liang Shi could say whatever she wanted to say even when facing that icy expression.

But before she could speak further, Zhao Xuning said first: "I'm the one who owes her."

Liang Shi nodded: "Oh, so you do know. If you like her, then go chase her. If you can't win her over, then let go. She's about to get married to someone else, and you want to go crash it? Gu Yixue was exploiting a loophole and seizing an opportunity. What you'd be doing is purely being an annoyance..."

The last few words gradually faded under Zhao Xuning's murderous gaze.

But Liang Shi still couldn't hold back. "You blockhead¹. Why don't you just chase her properly? As long as she's not married yet, you still have a chance. If you don't do anything, is she supposed to wait for you her whole life?"

Zhao Xuning: "....."

After a long while, Zhao Xuning asked seriously: "How do I chase her?"

Liang Shi was stunned: "How did you chase her back then?"

Zhao Xuning: "....."

Obviously, Zhao Xuning hadn't chased her back then.

Her getting together with Shen Hui was indeed quite dramatic. She was just standing on the sports field when her eyes swept over and landed on Shen Hui running. After their eyes met, she got her phone number.

A few days later, they were in a relationship.

Back then, it seemed like Shen Hui was even the one who asked for the phone number first.

Zhao Xuning really was quite the blockhead.

Although they had dated for several years, she really had never chased anyone. When she was with Shen Hui, she was a decent girlfriend, and later Shen Hui had trained her to be somewhat docile. But she still couldn't change her bad temper.

Though that bad temper was only toward outsiders. When it came to Shen Hui, she was always helpless.

Footnotes:

¹ **Blockhead (榆木脑袋):** Literally "elm wood head." Elm wood is known for being hard and difficult to work with, so this phrase describes someone who is stubborn, dense, or slow to understand—particularly in matters of emotion or social situations.

Chapter 164-6

Looking at the slow-witted Zhao Xuning, Liang Shi sighed and remarked: "God is fair. When he opens a door for you, he closes a window."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

Zhao Xuning threw a pillow at her. "Do you have any idea why you've been staying at my place these past days? What are you saying as someone who's about to get divorced?"

Liang Shi: ".....A piece of news."

Zhao Xuning: "Hm? You're not divorcing anymore?"

Liang Shi nodded: "That's right. But how did you know? Oh right, did you know all along that the company was acquired by Xu Qingzhu?"

Zhao Xuning: "I only knew one day before you."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Also..." Liang Shi paused. "Zhuzi is pregnant."

This news actually shocked Zhao Xuning. "Pregnant?"

"Yes." Liang Shi said, "It's been a while now. I didn't even know."

Zhao Xuning, afraid of being wrongly blamed again, immediately clarified: "I didn't know about this either."

The two suddenly paused at this point. After a while, the topic circled back.

Liang Shi stared at Zhao Xuning and said earnestly: "You geniuses are just too arrogant. Try seeing yourself as an ordinary person sometimes. Communicate properly."

Zhao Xuning: ".....Get to the point."

"How many years would you get for talking nicely where you're from?"¹ Liang Shi retorted.

Zhao Xuning was stunned: "What does that mean?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Forget it. Why did she expect this lofty flower² to understand internet slang?

But she couldn't let the "landlord" who had taken her in for so many days stay so troubled. Liang Shi could only speak from her own shallow experience: "If you two love each other, then go tell her. Apologize properly. If you can reconcile, reconcile. If you can get back together, get back together. If you can't... then just wish her happiness."

Hearing this, Zhao Xuning closed her eyes. Her body leaning against the sofa looked exhausted. She pinched the bridge of her nose and said: "Yes, I really do want to wish her happiness. But... I keep thinking about her. I keep feeling like she has some wounds that I need to heal."

Like those wounds that belonged to the two of them.

She needed Shen Hui.

When Zhao Xuning heard the news of Shen Hui's upcoming engagement last night, her whole being went numb. She sat by the bed all night without sleeping.

She didn't smoke, but last night she smoked a few cigarettes, drank some alcohol, and even took melatonin—yet still couldn't sleep.

The moment she closed her eyes, all she saw was Shen Hui calling out to her.

This morning, she filed an annual leave request directly with the hospital and holed up at home wasting time.

If she could drag the progress bar of life, Zhao Xuning would have wanted to drag it straight to the end.

Just let her die already.

Life really seemed to have no solution.

The feeling of doing something wrong was like standing at a fork in the road—once you chose wrong, there was no turning back.

Zhao Xuning didn't know how to describe this feeling to Liang Shi. She just said wearily: "I'll try."

Liang Shi invited her out to eat. She originally wanted to say no, but upon hearing that Xu Qingzhu was also downstairs, she went back to her room to change clothes and headed out.

Someone who usually wore a white coat to work was now wearing a white coat as outerwear too.

Zhao Xuning wore glasses, and with this outfit, she looked exactly like a refined scoundrel³.

Liang Shi stood at the doorway and clicked her tongue: "You totally have the face of a player."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

After going downstairs, Zhao Xuning greeted Xu Qingzhu, then became invisible.

She wasn't just here to eat—she was also out to clear her mind.

If she could find even a sliver of an exit from her current predicament, that would be even better.

But when she asked Xu Qingzhu during the meal, Xu Qingzhu could only answer after thinking for a few seconds: "Have a serious, patient conversation."

Xu Qingzhu had stronger logical abilities than Liang Shi. After dating Liang Shi, she had also become self-taught in the subject of romance, so when speaking to Zhao Xuning, she was clear and systematic.

Zhao Xuning seemed to understand, yet also kind of didn't.

But she did drink quite a lot of alcohol.

After several rounds of drinks, Zhao Xuning's phone rang. It was a college classmate inviting her to a gathering.

She originally didn't want to go, but upon hearing that the person who was about to get engaged to Shen Hui would be there, Zhao Xuning called a car and left.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu stood in place, watching the car drive away.

After a long while, Liang Shi shook her head to herself: "Why does it feel like Zhao Xuning is kind of pitiful?"

Xu Qingzhu was startled: "Who isn't pitiful?"

Liang Shi looked at her.

Xu Qingzhu said quietly: "Sister Hui is pitiful too."

Liang Shi nodded.

Xu Qingzhu added: "I'm pitiful too."

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi was about to say how are you pitiful, but then she thought of everything Xu Qingzhu had said during the day and found herself at a loss for words.

Xu Qingzhu continued: "You're pitiful too."

Liang Shi immediately denied it: "I'm not pitiful. I have such a cute wife. I'm doing great."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly, resting her chin on her hand as she sat there, her eyes sparkling as she gazed at Liang Shi. "Everyone who falls into love is pitiful."

"Then why fall into it?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu lightly pressed her lips together, her voice very soft: "How would I know~ Anyway, I've fallen for you."

¹ **"How many years would you get for talking nicely where you're from?":** This is a Chinese internet meme/joke that implies someone is so bad at communicating nicely that it must be illegal where they come from. It's a humorous way of criticizing someone's poor communication skills.

² **Lofty flower (高嶺之花):** A Japanese-origin term (takane no hana) commonly used in Chinese, referring to someone who seems unreachable or unapproachable, like a flower growing on a high peak—beautiful but distant and hard to get.

³ **Refined scoundrel (斯文敗類):** A Chinese expression describing someone who looks cultured and genteel on the outside but is actually morally corrupt or mischievous inside. It's often used in a teasing or flirtatious context to describe someone who looks intellectual but has a "bad boy/girl" appeal.